

DECISIVE MOMENT

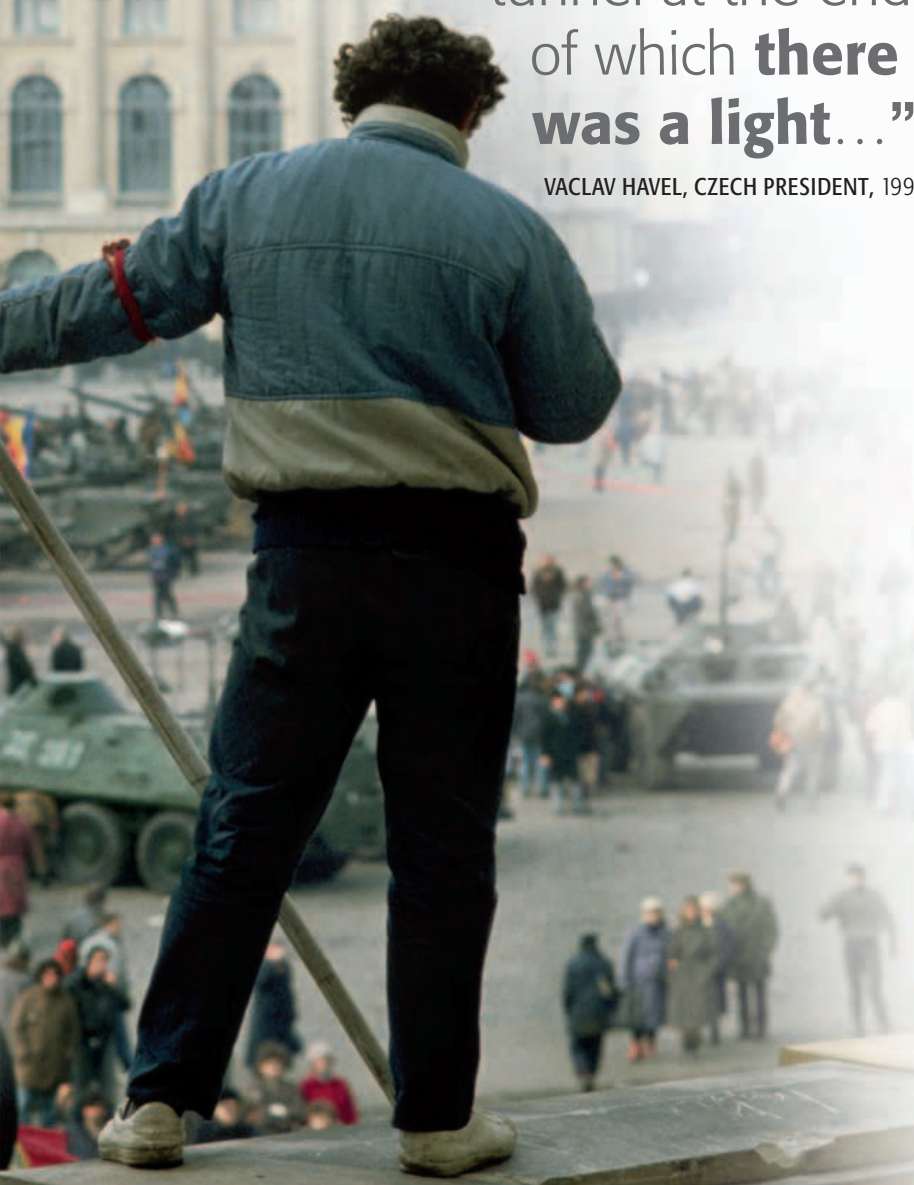
THE FALL OF THE BERLIN WALL

The Berlin Wall was the most famous physical manifestation of the Iron Curtain. The East German government built the wall in 1961 to prevent skilled workers from crossing into West Berlin to work, describing it as an “anti-Fascist Protective Rampart.” For the next 30 years movement of citizens between West and East was highly restricted. During this time it has been claimed that as many as 200 people were shot by East German guards as they tried to escape to the West. In the 1970s and 1980s, graffiti artists covered the western side of the wall with paintings and slogans protesting at the division of Berlin. On November 9, 1989, when the abandonment of border controls was announced, tens of thousands of celebrating Berliners converged on the wall. Over the following days, the city’s inhabitants began to dismantle the wall with their own hands.



“People have passed through a very dark tunnel at the end of which **there was a light...**”

VACLAV HAVEL, CZECH PRESIDENT, 1990



under the communist regime. The communist government attempted to repress Solidarity, but, by 1989, was forced to accept more open elections. Solidarity was elected as Poland’s largest governing party by a huge majority, and its founder, Lech Walesa, served as president from 1990 to 1995.

Democracy spreads

1989 also saw the “Velvet Revolution” in Czechoslovakia, when mass protests secured the overthrow of the communist government. Alexander Dubček, hero of the Prague Spring (see BEFORE), was brought back from political isolation to serve in a new federal parliament. Hungary and Bulgaria also made peaceful transitions to democracy in the early 1990s. The Hungarian communist government tried offering reforms while maintaining a one-party system, but popular pressure led to the declaration of the Third Hungarian Republic and the promise of multi-party elections. Both Hungary and Bulgaria became parliamentary democracies in 1990.

CZECH WRITER AND STATESMAN (1936–)

VACLAV HAVEL

Born into a wealthy and cultured family, Havel’s “bourgeois” roots meant that he was not entitled to a university education. In the 1960s Havel’s first plays were produced on stage, but his work became increasingly subversive and he was imprisoned for dissent. Havel was elected president of Czechoslovakia after the Velvet Revolution. Profoundly convinced that a politician should follow his individual conscience, his decisions as president were often controversial. Havel resigned in 1992, but was reelected in 1993 and remained in office until 2003.

The transition to democracy triggered nationalist conflicts and economic hardship.

WAR IN YUGOSLAVIA

In 1992, waves of nationalist sentiment led to the violent dismemberment of the communist Federation of Yugoslavia 450–51 >>

NATO IN EASTERN EUROPE

NATO 397 >> has expanded since the fall of communism to include most former Warsaw Pact countries. Consultations on international security are held between NATO and non-members, including Russia and Ukraine.

THE ORANGE REVOLUTION

Thousands took to the streets of Kiev, Ukraine, to protest the disputed election in 2004. This forced a revote that brought pro-EU leader Viktor Yushchenko to power, but five years later the Orange coalition had collapsed and he was defeated in presidential elections by his former opponent from 2004.



CAMPING OUT IN KIEV

Violent overthrow

Romania’s communist leader, Nicolae Ceaușescu, ran a particularly repressive and ruthless regime. His overthrow in 1989 is the one instance of violent revolution during this period. Ceaușescu was arrested and subsequently shot by the army. He was succeeded by Ion Iliescu, a former member of the communist regime. Iliescu, a dominant political figure in Romania since the revolution, helped develop a brand of democratic socialism that retains some policies from the communist era. The last Eastern Bloc state to adopt parliamentary democracy was Albania, in 1992. Charges of corruption and economic mismanagement followed, but by 2007 that country seemed to be progressing toward full democracy.

